

EMERALD PRIZE 2026

A PREPARATION GUIDE FOR ARTISTS

Themes, Techniques & AI-Assisted Design Tips

Emerald Prize — International Art Competition

Emerald Horizon Ventures · emeraldprize.com

Welcome

This guide is here to help you approach your Emerald Prize entry with a clear plan — whether you're working in Traditional Art or AI-Assisted Digital Design. It covers how to interpret your age group's theme, practical technique guidance, and what makes a strong AI-Assisted process document.

There's no single "correct" way to interpret a theme. The ideas in this guide are starting points meant to spark your own thinking, not a template to copy exactly.

A Quick Recap of the Format

Emerald Prize is an individual entry competition (no teams), with two categories: Traditional Art, and AI-Assisted Digital Design (which requires a 1-page process document alongside your artwork).

Age groups and themes: Primary (Grades 1–5) — "My World"; Middle (Grades 6–9) — "My Culture"; Senior (Grades 10–12) — "My Vision."

Deadline: October 15, 2026. Every entrant receives a certificate of participation, and medal winners (Gold, Silver, Bronze) are invited to the Global Finals in Hong Kong this December.

Part One — Theme Inspiration by Age Group

Primary (Grades 1–5) — "My World"

At this age, the strongest entries usually come from something the student knows intimately and can draw or design with real detail and feeling — not a generic, imagined scene.

1. A place in your home or neighborhood that feels special to you, drawn from your own point of view.
2. A typical day in your life, shown as a sequence of small scenes.
3. Your family or pet, doing something you love watching them do.
4. Something in nature you see every day but rarely stop to look closely at — a tree, a bug, clouds.
5. An imaginary creature that could only exist in your own neighborhood.
6. Your favorite meal, and the story of who makes it and why it matters to you.

Middle (Grades 6–9) — "My Culture"

This theme rewards specificity. A piece about "my culture" in general terms is much weaker than a piece about one particular tradition, object, food, or story that means something personal to the student.

1. A festival or celebration from your culture, focusing on one specific detail (a food, a color, a sound) rather than the whole event.
2. An object passed down in your family — what it looks like, and the story behind it.
3. A traditional pattern, textile, or art style from your culture, reimagined in your own style.
4. Two cultures you belong to or have been influenced by, shown together in one piece.
5. A proverb, folk tale, or saying from your culture, illustrated literally or symbolically.
6. What your culture looks like today versus a generation ago, shown side by side.

Senior (Grades 10–12) — "My Vision"

"My Vision" is intentionally open — judges are looking for a genuine point of view, not just technical skill. The strongest entries usually take a clear stance on something the student actually cares about.

1. A problem in the world you want to see solved, and what solving it might look like.
2. A vision of your own life or community 10 years from now.
3. A personal belief or value visualized as a symbolic scene, not stated literally.
4. Something you wish more people understood, communicated without using any words.
5. The tension between tradition and change, from your own perspective.
6. A reinterpretation of a historical event or figure through a modern lens.

Part Two — Category-Specific Guidance

Traditional Art

1. Choose your medium deliberately. Watercolor, colored pencil, acrylic, charcoal, and collage all communicate different moods — pick one that matches the feeling of your theme, not just the one you're most comfortable with by default.
2. Plan your composition before you commit color. A quick thumbnail sketch (even the size of a postage stamp) showing where major shapes and focal points go will save you from a piece that feels unbalanced later.
3. Use contrast to guide the eye. The area with the strongest contrast in your piece (lightest light next to darkest dark) will naturally draw attention first — make sure that's where you want the viewer to look.
4. Leave believable imperfection. Judges can usually tell the difference between a piece that was carefully made by a student and one that was traced or heavily copied from a reference photo without any personal interpretation.
5. Document your process with a few photos as you work — even if not required for Traditional Art, it's a good habit and can support you if judges ever have questions about authorship.

AI-Assisted Digital Design

This category is judged on more than the final image — your process document matters. Here's how to make it strong:

1. The process document is not a formality — it's part of what's being judged. Treat it as seriously as the artwork itself.
2. Be specific about your role. Explain which creative decisions were yours (concept, composition, color direction, iteration choices) versus what the AI tool generated or suggested.
3. Show your iteration, not just your final prompt. Include 2–3 earlier versions or attempts and explain what you changed and why — this demonstrates genuine creative direction rather than a single lucky output.
4. Name your tools specifically. "I used an AI image generator" is weaker than naming the actual tool and describing the settings or approach you used.
5. Don't let AI make all the aesthetic decisions. The strongest AI-Assisted entries show a human artist directing a tool with intention — choosing a style, refining a composition, combining multiple outputs — not simply accepting the first result.
6. Keep a running note of your prompts and key decisions as you work, rather than trying to reconstruct your process from memory right before the deadline.

Part Three — Composition & Technique Fundamentals

These principles apply whether you're painting, drawing, or designing digitally.

Rule of Thirds

Imagine your piece divided into a 3x3 grid. Placing key elements along these lines or their intersections, rather than dead-center, often creates a more dynamic, natural-feeling composition.

Focal Point

Every strong piece has one clear place the eye is drawn to first. If everything in your piece is equally detailed and colorful, the viewer won't know where to look — deliberately simplify secondary areas to support your focal point.

Color Mood

Warm colors (reds, oranges, yellows) tend to feel energetic or urgent; cool colors (blues, greens, purples) tend to feel calm or distant. Choosing a dominant color temperature that matches your theme's emotion strengthens the piece.

Negative Space

The empty areas around your subject matter as much as the subject itself. Cramming a piece edge-to-edge with detail can feel cluttered — intentional empty space can make the subject feel more powerful.

Visual Storytelling

Ask yourself: if someone saw this piece with no title or caption, could they guess what it's about? A piece that communicates its idea visually, without relying on an explanatory label, is generally stronger.

Part Four — A Worked Example

Here's how a Middle-group student ("My Culture") might develop an AI-Assisted Digital Design entry from theme to finished submission.

Step 1 — Find the Specific Angle

Instead of "my culture" broadly, the student focuses on their grandmother's hand-embroidery patterns, which she still makes but which younger family members have never learned.

Step 2 — Sketch the Concept

Before touching any AI tool, the student sketches a rough composition idea by hand: the embroidery pattern flowing from an elderly hand into a young hand, transforming as it moves.

Step 3 — Generate & Iterate

The student uses an AI image tool to generate several versions of the concept, adjusting the prompt each time to better match the sketch — noting in their process document what changed between attempts 1, 2, and 3, and why.

Step 4 — Refine with Intention

The student isn't satisfied with the AI's default color palette, which felt too generic, so they specifically direct the tool toward the warm gold and deep red tones actually used in their grandmother's real embroidery, based on a reference photo.

Step 5 — Write the Process Document

The final process document names the specific tool used, includes 2 earlier iterations alongside the final piece, and explains the personal story behind the concept — giving judges both the technical process and the human meaning behind it.

Notice this entry didn't rely on the AI tool's first output. The strongest AI-Assisted pieces show a real creative direction the student pushed toward — not just an accepted first draft.

Part Five — Final Tips Before You Submit

1. Read your theme carefully and choose the most specific, personal interpretation you can think of — avoid the most obvious, generic response to the prompt.
2. Start earlier than feels necessary. Strong pieces usually go through at least one revision after the artist steps away and comes back with fresh eyes.
3. If entering AI-Assisted Digital Design, write your process document as you go, not after you're already finished — you'll remember your decisions far more accurately.
4. Get one honest piece of feedback from someone before submitting — a teacher, parent, or friend who will tell you what's actually working and what isn't.
5. Double-check the submission requirements (file format, size, process document if applicable) well before the October 15 deadline so a technical issue doesn't cost you at the last minute.

Good Luck

Whatever direction you take your piece, the strongest entries share one thing in common: a genuine, specific point of view rather than a generic response to the theme. Take the time to find your own angle.

Questions about your entry, the submission process, or the Global Finals in Hong Kong? Reach out any time.

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